Michelson, Albert Abraham (1852–1931). German-born, American experimental physicist; Nobel laureate; invented the techniques of interferometry (Chapter 1); used those techniques to discover that the speed of light is independent of one's velocity through the Universe (Chapter 1).

Minkowski, Hermann (1864–1909). German theoretical physicist; teacher of Einstein (Chapter 1); discovered that space and time are unified into spacetime (Chapter 2).

Misner, Charles W. (b. 1932). American theoretical physicist; student of Wheeler's; developed an insightful embedding diagram description of how an imploding star produces a black hole (Chapter 6); created a research group that contributed significantly to the "golden age" of black-hole research (Chapter 7); discovered that electromagnetic and other waves propagating near a spinning black hole can extract rotational energy from the hole and use it to amplify themselves (Chapter 12); discovered the oscillatory, "mixmaster" oscillations of tidal gravity near singularities (Chapter 13).

Newton, Isaac (1642–1727). British natural philosopher; developed the foundations for the Newtonian laws of physics and for the concept of space and time as absolute (Chapter 1); developed the Newtonian laws of gravity (Chapter 2).

Novikov, Igor Dmitrievich (b. 1935). Soviet theoretical physicist and astrophysicist; student of Zel'dovich's; with Doroshkevich and Zel'dovich, developed some of the key initial evidence that a black hole has no hair (Chapter 7); with Zel'dovich, proposed the method for astronomical searches for black holes in our galaxy that seems to have finally succeeded (Chapter 8); with Thorne, developed the theory of the structures of accretion disks around black holes (Chapter 12); with Doroshkevich, predicted that the tidal forces inside a black hole must change as the hole ages (Chapter 13); carried out research on whether the laws of physics permit time machines (Chapter 14).

Oppenheimer, J. Robert (1904–1967). American theoretical physicist; transfused theoretical physics from Western Europe to the United States in the 1930s (Chapter 5); with Serber, disproved Landau's claim that stars might be kept hot by neutron cores, and with Volkoff, demonstrated that there is a maximum possible mass for neutron stars (Chapter 5); with Snyder, demonstrated, in a highly idealized model, that when massive stars die, they must implode to form black holes, and elucidated key features of